



Photographs by ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times; Times photo illustration

Mexicans uneasy over graft and crime

BY PATRICK J. McDONNELL AND KATE LINTHICUM

MEXICO CITY — Tens of thousands of Mexicans are set to gather downtown Sunday in a choreographed tribute to President Claudia Sheinbaum, who closed out her initial year in office with approval ratings north of 70%.

Apart from her personal popularity as Mexico's first woman president, polls show strong support among poor and working-class Mexicans for her continuation of social-aid programs launched by her predecessor and mentor, ex-President Andrés Manuel López Obrador.

Sheinbaum, who took office last Oct. 1, has embraced and expanded López Obrador's leftist social agenda, often repeating his mantra: "For the good of all, the poor first."

But, amid the plaudits, [See Mexico, A6]

A year of dying for marine life

BY SUSANNE RUST

DAVENPORT, Calif. — On a spit of sand 12 miles north of Santa Cruz, a small, emaciated sea lion lay on its side. The only sign of life was the deep press of its flippers against its belly, relaxing for a few seconds, then squeezing again.

"That's a classic sign of lepto," said Giancarlo Rulli, a volunteer and spokesperson with the Marine Mammal Center, pointing to the young animal's wretched self-embrace. The corkscrew-shaped bacteria, leptospirosis, causes severe abdominal pain in sea lions by damaging their kidneys and inflaming their gastrointestinal tracts. "They hold their stomach just like that. Like a sick child with a bellyache," he said.

Since the end of June, officials say nearly 400 animals have been reported stranded or sickened along the Central Coast beaches. More than two-thirds of [See Marine, A12]

22,500 homes lost.
More than 5 years later, only 38% rebuilt:
What California fire survivors face.

THE ROAD TO REBUILDING

By Liam Dillon, Ben Poston, Doug Smith and Jessica Garrison
REPORTING FROM SANTA ROSA, CALIF.

On a hill in Sonoma County, François Piccin yearns to return home.

In fall 2017, Piccin and his wife lost their ranch house when the Tubbs fire roared through Northern California's famed wine region.

Contractors found themselves in high demand and overbooked, and the one the couple hired abandoned the project halfway through. In the time it took to find a new builder, the price tag rose by a third to \$2.4 million, forcing the Piccins to sell a rental property they owned to pay the bill.

The home remains unfinished and their lives unsettled.

"Financially, what we've done doesn't make sense," said Piccin, 66, standing this summer amid cardboard delivery boxes and stray cabinet drawers in his future kitchen. "But emotionally, psychologically, it is a mandate. We need to have this done to be able to close a chapter and turn the page."

Over the last eight years, wildfires have burned down more houses than at any other time in California history. From the Piccins' property in wine country to foothills below the Sierra Nevada to canyons overlooking the Pacific Ocean, the wreck-

age stubbornly resists recovery.

To better understand what Los Angeles might expect after January's fires, The Times examined the five other most destructive wildfires from this period to document how communities have responded in the wake of disaster.

In total, nearly 22,500 homes were lost in the five blazes, which occurred from 2017 to 2020. Just 8,400 — 38% — had been rebuilt as of April per the Times analysis.

It's not for lack of trying. In more than 50 interviews, wildfire-affected homeowners and renters, builders, academics, aid workers and government officials described the myriad ways rebuilding has failed. Insurance came up short. Construction costs soared. Red tape stifled. Life intervened. The desire of many fire survivors to return to their homes ran aground amid the challenges.

Now, with 13,000 homes lost this year in Los Angeles County, these experiences offer a scope into the future. Immediately after the blazes, the neighborhoods of Pacific Palisades and Altadena vowed to come back as they were before. Elected officials promised to do everything in their power to make that happen. But the same was said when the earlier fires reduced other areas to rubble.

[See Rebuilding, A8]

Younger, richer and smaller: Wildfire era changed communities forever

BY LIAM DILLON, BEN POSTON, DOUG SMITH AND JESSICA GARRISON

PARADISE, Calif. — When Jen Goodlin visited Paradise six months after the 2018 Camp fire, she thought she was saying goodbye.

A town native, Goodlin was living in Colorado with her husband and four children. She wanted to witness the devastation that wiped out 10,700 homes, including the small white cottage where she grew up, and turned the dense forest of her youth into a bleak landscape. But once she arrived, she was surprised at her reaction. She could envision so much more than the burned trees and abandoned



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times
A ROADSIDE sign remains years after the devastating Camp fire.

Little aid received

"Now there is nothing for us": Towns disappear when wildfire survivors can't rebuild. A10

businesses around her.

Here, she saw, her family could live on a big piece of land as they'd always wanted. Her husband thought she was crazy, but they ran the numbers, bought a 1.2-acre vacant lot and put a trailer on the property. A few years later, they moved into a new, four-bedroom house.

"It took the fire to bring me home," said Goodlin, 43, who now runs a local wildfire recovery nonprofit.

Young families like Goodlin's are coming to Paradise, shifting the town's demographics away from the retirees who once lived there. Attracted by cheap land — lots cost less than a mid-range car — newcomers can [See Communities, A11]

Trump's executive powers face test

Birthright citizenship, tariffs and other crucial issues may be where the Supreme Court draws the line.

BY DAVID G. SAVAGE

WASHINGTON — Supreme Court justices like to talk about the Constitution's separation of powers and how it limits the exercise of official authority.

But Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. and his conservative colleagues have given no sign so far they will check President Trump's one-man governance by executive order.

To the contrary, the conservative justices have repeatedly ruled for Trump on fast-track appeals and overturned federal judges who said the president had exceeded his authority.

The court's new term opens on Monday, and the justices will begin hearing arguments.

But those regularly scheduled cases have been overshadowed by Trump's relentless drive to remake the government, to punish his political enemies, including universities, law firms, TV networks and prominent Democrats, and to send [See High court, A12]

DODGERS IN NL DIVISION SERIES

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UCLA stuns No. 7 Penn State

Nico Iamaleava accounts for five touchdowns as Bruins win first game. SPORTS, B8

Signs of hope at Tel Aviv rally

Hostage Square, site of weekly protests, celebrates U.S. ceasefire proposal. WORLD, A4

Weather Sunshine.

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